

Through Rough Waters to Safe Harbor

Reflections on the economics job market search · Remy Beauregard

Hi everyone,

Congratulations on all your hard work making it to the job market! I will try to offer my thoughts here without repeating too much what others have already said; please check out [Alaa](#) and [Peppe](#)'s reflections as well.

To start, some important affirmations: you are an incredible economist, you will find a job, and that job will be lucky to have you. Imposter syndrome and excessive self-doubt are the silent killers of progress, but know you can hold your head high with all you have accomplished. I was constantly keeping tabs on my emotions during the process to make sure I was not getting bogged down in feelings of pessimism or futility, as these can trap you in a negative spiral. Take critique and feedback as they come, do not be afraid to learn from your mistakes, but always remember the talent and skill that brought you to Davis and trust it to take you farther. The job market needs YOUR perspective on research, not just a carbon copy of someone else!

My first general recommendation is to spend significant time interrogating your own job preferences, as the entire search process (across advisors, Jenna¹, Kaitlin², etc.) will hinge on finding the best match for you. If you are not certain of your preferences or do not feel strongly about your next step, that is okay, but still try to identify some representative or prototypical job openings you feel would be a good fit for you (Jenna often asks you to do this explicitly). This is the real challenge of the market: preferences are constructed in response to the distribution of postings, but this distribution evolves constantly throughout the search process. Make sure to check job postings often, follow multiple job boards, and set up email blasts when new openings that meet your search criteria are posted. A good job match is a place where you will do your best work, feel supported and fulfilled, and be excited to continue your research. This feeds into my second (and probably most critical) point,

Open communication! It is absolutely imperative to be in high-frequency contact with your advisors, dissertation committee/letter writers, and Jenna throughout the job market process, whether it is going well, poorly, or somewhere in the middle. If your advisors do not understand the types of jobs you are targeting, they cannot write you the best letter of recommendation. If Jenna does not know

the current state of your market, she cannot internally promote you most effectively. Advisors can also help narrow down options if you are still unsure of your search criteria; take their suggestions into consideration, of course, but above all be honest with them about what you want and what you do not. In this spirit,

Your job market should honestly and accurately reflect YOU. Proofread your documents carefully and ensure they are in their best shape before sending out applications, checking that they faithfully capture your voice. Remember that a committee is not hiring a job market paper or a teaching evaluation; they are hiring a dynamic person with a long future trajectory in economics. Your materials should show off both what you have accomplished so far and what you hope to do in the future. If you do not have much experience in a certain area but would like to gain more, say this. If you have mostly done work in one field but hope to break into a second, say this. Your application materials should not be a sterilized or cookie-cutter version of someone else's template, but a true best representation of your own talent, interests, hopes, and plans. As above, send these to your advisors and letter writers early and often; drafts help them get a full picture of how you are representing yourself on the market and tighten their letters of recommendation.

Above all else, remember to give yourself PEACE during this process. The job market, whether long or short, easy or difficult, lush or barren, is uncertain and often demoralizing. Avoid over-interpreting negative signals or internalizing a lack of responses; all jobs have secret preferences and selection criteria over which they make decisions and that you may never learn about. Keep yourself healthy, make time for family and friends, iterate on constructive critique as it comes, and remember that you WILL land a good job at the end of this matching process (it just may take longer or look slightly different than you were expecting). Network, ask for support, be honest with yourself about how you are doing, and lean on your peers when things are tough. We are all here to support you and help you find your best job fit possible!

Best of luck and fair winds,

Remy

Notes

1. Jenna Stearns, placement committee chair at the time of writing.

2. Kaitlin Aparicio, graduate program coordinator at the time of writing.